IOWN

The Morning Brief

MARCH 30, 2026

Widening

Houthis open a new front, Iran strikes Gulf aluminum smelters, and Brent posts its steepest monthly surge on record — but Pakistan-hosted talks and Trump's "new regime" claim lift Monday futures.

S&P 500	BRENT CRUDE	BITCOIN	GOLD	FEAR & GREED
6,341 ↓1.71%	~$113 ↑4.3%	~$66,200 ↓3.7%	~$4,550 ↑3.5%	8 · Extreme Fear

SECTION 01

Markets

FRIDAY EXTENDS THE ROUT — BUT MONDAY FUTURES OPEN HIGHER ON DIPLOMATIC SIGNALS

Friday delivered another broad-based selloff: the S&P 500 fell 1.71%, the Dow dropped 1.72%, the Nasdaq shed 1.95%, and the Russell 2000 declined 1.75%. UVXY surged 11.99%—another double-digit volatility spike. TLT fell 0.55%, offering no bond refuge. Financials (–2.53%) and discretionary (–2.89%) led losses, while energy (+1.69%) was again the sole meaningful gainer. Brent surged to approximately $113, its highest close since July 2022, putting the benchmark on track for its steepest monthly gain on record at approximately 55%. DVY (–0.35%) dramatically outperformed IUSG (–2.07%)—the dividend sleeve continues to provide structural downside protection. Monday premarket, however, has reversed: S&P futures are up approximately 0.76% to 6,461, Dow futures gaining 0.74%, and Nasdaq futures adding 0.71%. The catalyst: Trump posted on Truth Social that the US is in "serious discussions with A NEW, AND MORE REASONABLE, REGIME," and Pakistan announced readiness to host "meaningful talks" between the US and Iran in the coming days. Whether this produces substance or another false start is the question that defines the week.

GOLD REBOUNDS +3.51% — MINERS LEAD FOR THE THIRD TIME IN TWO WEEKS

Gold rallied 3.51% on Friday, with GLD closing at $414.70, placing spot gold near $4,550. Silver surged 4.39%. IOWN's gold miners led the portfolio: GFI gained 4.54% and AEM added 3.11%, both outperforming the underlying metal. Miners have now outperformed gold on multiple up sessions in the past two weeks—a pattern that historically tends to signal institutional positioning ahead of a sustained rally rather than mechanical short covering. Gold is now trading near $4,566 in early Monday trading, up 0.93% overnight. The inverted safe-haven dynamic identified in prior briefs persists: gold rallied Friday even as oil surged, suggesting the forced-liquidation selling that dominated mid-March may have fully exhausted. J.P. Morgan's year-end target of $6,300 and Goldman Sachs's $5,400

forecast both imply significant upside from current levels if the structural case reasserts.

ENERGY SLEEVE CONTINUES TO LEAD

VLO gained 2.49% to $254.32, CVX added 1.62% to $211.15, OKE rose 0.42%, and CNX added 1.42%. The XLE has been among the few sectors consistently posting gains during the conflict. Brent crude closed near $113 on Friday and is trading at approximately $115 in Monday premarket, with CNBC reporting the benchmark is heading for its steepest monthly surge on record—up approximately 55% in March alone, surpassing the previous record of 46% set during the Gulf War in September 1990. WTI briefly crossed triple digits on Friday and is trading near that level again this morning. The energy sleeve thesis has been validated through the most severe supply disruption since the 1973 embargo: CVX, VLO, and OKE are among the only IOWN holdings posting gains over the past two weeks. The question is whether the April 6 deadline brings a resolution that unwinds the premium or an escalation that pushes oil toward the elevated levels seen earlier this month.

DIGITAL SLEEVE TAKES THE HEAVIEST HIT OF THE CONFLICT

COIN plunged 7.06% to $161.14, MARA fell 6.53%, HUT dropped 6.28%, HOOD declined 6.15%, and IBIT shed 3.66%. Bitcoin is trading near $66,500 on Monday morning after hitting weekend lows near $65,900. Ethereum touched $1,980 before recovering to approximately $2,068 this morning. The crypto Fear & Greed index remains at extreme fear levels. The sleeve's correlation with growth and tech rather than safe-haven assets has been confirmed through the entire conflict: as equities sell off and oil surges, crypto sells in sympathy rather than providing diversification. On the constructive side, Morgan Stanley's spot Bitcoin ETF (MSBT) received its NYSE listing notice last week and Bloomberg's Balchunas indicated the launch appears imminent. The medium-term structural case—16,000 Morgan Stanley advisors with access to a proprietary BTC product—has not changed, but the near-term price action remains hostage to geopolitical risk.

S&P 500	**6,341 Fri · Futures ↑0.76% Mon AM to 6,461**
BRENT CRUDE	**~$113 Fri · ~$115 Mon AM · ↑55% in March (record)**
GOLD	**~$4,550 Fri · ~$4,566 Mon AM · Miners outperforming**
ALUMINUM (LME)	**↑6% to $3,492/ton · 4-year high · Iran struck Gulf smelters**
UVXY	**↑11.99% Fri · Double-digit vol spike**
FEAR & GREED	**8 · Extreme Fear · New conflict low**

Weeks of consecutive declines. Both the Dow and Nasdaq in correction territory. Fear & Greed at 8. Oil posting its steepest monthly surge on record. And yet Monday futures open higher on diplomatic hope from Pakistan. The pattern repeats: hope trades are bought and sold within 48 hours. The portfolio does not trade the pattern—it is positioned through it. Avoid Erosion—discipline compounds; impulse erodes.

Geopolitics

HOUTHIS ENTER THE WAR — THE THIRD CHOKEPOINT IS NOW IN PLAY

Yemen's Houthi movement fired ballistic missiles at southern Israel on Saturday, marking the group's formal entry into the month-old conflict. Israel's military intercepted the projectiles. A Houthi spokesman indicated attacks would continue until military operations across all fronts cease. The immediate military impact appears limited, but the strategic implications could be significant. The Houthis have not yet moved to close the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, the 16-mile-wide Red Sea chokepoint through which approximately 10% of global seaborne oil passes. This distinction matters: Saudi Arabia has specifically increased Red Sea shipments to bypass the Hormuz closure. If the Houthis escalate from missile strikes to maritime interdiction—a capability they demonstrated extensively in 2024—the last major alternative route for Gulf oil is eliminated. The resulting scenario, in which Hormuz, the Suez alternative, and Bab el-Mandeb are simultaneously disrupted, would have no clear modern precedent. MATX is directly exposed to global shipping disruption. CVX, VLO, and OKE could benefit from further supply tightening.

IRAN STRIKES GULF ALUMINUM SMELTERS — WAR REACHES INDUSTRIAL SUPPLY CHAINS

In a significant escalation beyond energy infrastructure, Iran struck Emirates Global Aluminium in Abu Dhabi and Aluminium Bahrain over the weekend, according to Bloomberg. EGA reported "significant damage" at its Al Taweelah site, while Alba is assessing facility damage. Iran's Revolutionary Guards stated the strikes were retaliation for US-Israeli attacks on Iranian steel plants. LME aluminum surged approximately 6% to $3,492 per ton on Monday, its highest level in four years. LME warehouse stocks have dropped more than 60% since May. Analysts at Britannia Global Markets warned the strikes could push aluminum toward $4,000 per ton. For IOWN, the direct exposure is limited, but the second-order effects are meaningful: STLD (–1.98% Friday) and CAT (–1.11%) are both sensitive to industrial metals pricing dynamics, while the aluminum disruption adds another dimension to the inflation overhang that constrains the Fed.

PAKISTAN HOSTS TALKS — THE DIPLOMATIC WINDOW CRACKS OPEN AGAIN

Pakistan hosted a two-day summit beginning Sunday, bringing together foreign ministers from Saudi Arabia, Turkey, and Egypt alongside US special envoy Witkoff. Pakistani Foreign Minister Dar announced that both the US and Iran have expressed confidence in Pakistan to facilitate "meaningful talks" in the coming days—which, if they occur, would represent the first direct or mediated negotiations since the war began on February 28. Trump amplified the signal, posting that the US is in "serious discussions with A NEW, AND MORE REASONABLE, REGIME." The reference to a "new regime" is notable: since the strike that killed Supreme Leader Khamenei on February 28, the political authority structure in Tehran has been fragmented among military commanders, parliamentary leadership, and the surviving clerical establishment. Whether this fragmentation produces a negotiating partner or merely prolongs the absence of one is the fundamental uncertainty. Iran's parliament speaker continues to deny any negotiations are occurring. The April 6 deadline, when the pause on energy infrastructure strikes expires, is seven days away. Meanwhile, Iran warned that US ground troops would be "set on fire," and the

> Pentagon is reportedly preparing for weeks of limited ground operations according to the Washington Post.

HOUTHIS	**Entered war Saturday · Bab el-Mandeb threat unresolved**
ALUMINUM	**EGA (UAE) + Alba (Bahrain) struck · LME ↑6% to $3,492**
PAKISTAN TALKS	**Both sides express confidence · Talks “in coming days”**
US GROUND FORCES	**Pentagon planning limited ops · Iran: troops will be “on fire”**
APRIL 6 DEADLINE	**7 days · Energy strikes resume if no deal**
IRGC ULTIMATUM	**Threatens university targets by Monday midday**

SECTION 03

On Our Radar

1. Data-heavy week ahead, shortened by Good Friday. Tuesday brings Consumer Confidence from the Conference Board (10 AM ET)—February's reading of 91.2 is likely to decline given the University of Michigan's final March sentiment reading of 53.3. Nike (NKE) reports after Tuesday's close. Wednesday delivers ISM Manufacturing (10 AM ET)—February's 52.4 was expansionary but the prices-paid subindex at 70.5 signaled intense cost pressure. JOLTS job openings arrives Tuesday alongside Consumer Confidence, and ADP private payrolls follows Wednesday. Markets are closed Friday, April 3 for Good Friday. March nonfarm payrolls are released that morning at 8:30 AM ET per the BLS schedule—the market reaction is deferred entirely to the Monday, April 6 open, which is also when Trump's energy strike deadline expires. Two major catalysts converge on that single Monday morning. Research Reveals Opportunities.

2. Brent crude is posting its steepest monthly surge on record. At approximately $115, Brent has gained roughly 55% in March—surpassing the previous record of 46% set during the Gulf War in September 1990, according to CNBC. The energy sleeve is the portfolio's most important allocation through this environment. VLO has been among the portfolio's strongest performers throughout the conflict. CVX and OKE continue to provide earnings resilience. If the Pakistan talks produce a credible framework, oil could retrace sharply and the energy premium would compress. If they fail, the April 6 deadline could push Brent back toward the $120 levels seen earlier this month. Think Like an Owner—the energy thesis was designed for this volatility.

3. Aluminum's 6% surge introduces a new supply-chain dimension. Iran's strikes on EGA and Alba disrupted approximately 9% of global aluminum production capacity. LME warehouse stocks are down 60% from last May. Analysts warn prices could approach $4,000 per ton if the disruption persists. For IOWN, the direct read is through STLD (steel dynamics, sensitive to metals pricing) and CAT (industrial equipment, which faces both demand tailwinds from infrastructure spending and margin pressure from input costs). More broadly, aluminum inflation feeds through to automotive, construction, and packaging sectors—another channel through which the war constrains the Fed. **The physical world matters.**

4. Fear & Greed at 8 — the lowest reading of the conflict and approaching the floor of the index. The gauge has been in extreme fear territory for the entirety of the war. Readings this low have historically tended to precede recoveries, but the catalyst and timing remain uncertain—particularly with the April 6 deadline, payrolls, and the Houthi escalation all unresolved. The marginal seller is increasingly exhausted. But exhaustion is not the same as a floor. Avoid Erosion.

5. The April 6 convergence: deadline, payrolls, and reserve depletion. When the strike pause expires on April 6 at 8:00 PM ET, the market will also be digesting Friday's nonfarm payrolls (released while markets were closed for Good Friday) and approaching the mid-April window when strategic petroleum reserves could be depleted according to prior BCA Research analysis. If all three catalysts resolve negatively—weak payrolls, no ceasefire, reserves running low—the following week could represent the most challenging environment for global risk assets since the conflict began. The portfolio is positioned through that scenario, not around it. **Simplicity Over Complexity.**

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